

# 01

## The Three Jobs of an Ad Image

Document 1 of 8

New to this series? Start here — this document defines the vocabulary every other document uses.

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## The Wrong First Question

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When you look at an image and ask "is this a good image?", the honest answer is always another question: **good for what?**

Because there is no such thing as a good ad image in the abstract. An image that stops a cold scroller dead in a feed can be exactly the wrong image on a jump page. A photo that makes an advertorial feel like real journalism can be too soft, too composed, too "designed" to survive a native feed. The image is not judged against beauty, or polish, or even how much you like it. It is judged against a job — and the job changes depending on where the image lives.

So before any other advice in this series makes sense, you have to internalize the single most important habit in image selection: **name where the image lives first, then judge the image against that place's one job.** Skip that step and every downstream rule — faces, color, curiosity, composition — turns into folklore you apply at random. Keep that step and everything clicks into place.

This document gives you the map. The rest of the series fills in the terrain.

## The Three Places an Image Works

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There are two funnel routes in this system, and they are alternatives — a campaign runs one or the other, never both in sequence: **native ad** → **advertorial** → **sales page**, or **native ad** → **jump page** → **VSL**. Across those two routes, images do work in three places:

1. The **ad image** (the image inside the ad unit in the feed) — every campaign has one, whichever route it runs.
2. The **advertorial** image (photos inside the article-style page the click lands on, on the advertorial route).
3. The **jump page** image (the short bridge page the click lands on directly, on the jump-page route — a page whose only purpose is to get a video playing).

The advertorial and the jump page are not two stops on one path; they are the two possible pages your ad's click can land on. The jump page never follows the advertorial. So any single campaign uses two of the three places — the ad, plus whichever middle page its route runs — and each place puts the image in front of a reader in a different state of mind, so each one has a completely different job. Let's take them one at a time.

## 1. The Ad Image — Wins QUALIFIED Attention

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Your reader is at their absolute coldest here. They're scrolling an editorial feed in discovery mode — not shopping, not searching, not looking for you. They have hundreds of competing images sliding past per session, and their thumb is faster than their judgment. You have roughly a glance.

It's tempting to think the ad image's job is simply *clicks*. It isn't. The ad image's job is to stop the scroll for the **right** person and open a visual question the next page will answer. That word — right — is doing enormous work. An image that wins cheap, wrong clicks doesn't just waste money; it actively poisons the campaign, and we'll come back to exactly why in a moment.

To do this job the ad image has to read as **content, not as an ad**. One clear subject. Candid and unpolished. Nothing that looks designed, no text baked into the image, no pricing. The instant a reader's brain registers "this is an ad," the editorial camouflage collapses and the scroll continues. Success here isn't a big click number — it's a click from someone the advertorial can actually convert.

## 2. The Advertorial Image — Confirms the Scent

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Now the reader has clicked. They've landed on something that looks and feels like an article, and in the first second they are unconsciously asking one question: *did I land where I thought I would?*

The advertorial image's entire job is to answer that question with a confident **yes**. It confirms the scent — the trail of expectation the reader is following from the ad image. Same subject matter, same tone, same implicit promise as the image that earned the click.

If the ad image showed a weathered hand gripping a garden tool and the advertorial opens with a glossy studio product shot, the reader feels a tiny jolt of *wrong place* and starts drifting toward the back button, even if they can't name why.

So advertorial imagery stays in the editorial register: photos that could plausibly illustrate a real article, each one advancing the story the copy is telling rather than decorating around it. The reader is warmer now — they've demonstrated interest by clicking — so these images can carry more story than the ad image could. But they still can't look like advertising, because the whole power of the advertorial is that it doesn't feel like one.

### 3. The Jump Page Image — Builds Curiosity, Believability, and Momentum

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The jump page (also called a bridge page) is the short page whose only job is to get the video playing — and the reader arrives here straight from the feed, having clicked exactly one ad. They have not read an article, seen any proof, or been warmed by a story. But the curiosity loop the ad opened is still almost fully open — that loop is the engine of this page. Think of the jump page as a **second ad**: it has to re-win the reader's attention and convert it into a play, the same way the ad won the click.

The image on this page works with the headline as **one unit**, and its job is to keep the ad's loop open and aim it at the play button while making the promise feel real. "Believability" here means believed *attainability*: the hinted-at mechanism feels real and reachable behind the next click — not proof, not polish. Subject matter that makes the transformation feel attainable, carrying the same question the ad opened, pointing all momentum at the play button. The image still needs just enough visual legitimacy that pressing play feels safe — but that's a floor, not the job.

One minor permission rides along: because this page doesn't sit inside a feed, its imagery doesn't have to look grabbed on a phone the way an ad image does, so a touch more order is allowed. Composed is not the point and does not equal credible — the loop and the believable promise do that work — and "cleaner" never crosses into studio-branded advertising polish. Even at its most composed, the image stays believable, not slick.

## Why Cheap Wrong Clicks Poison Everything

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Come back to that warning about the ad image, because it's the reason "qualified" matters more than "maximum."

Imagine an ad image that tricks people into clicking — a jarring, sensational image that has nothing to do with the actual offer. It might pull a huge click-through rate. It also delivers a flood of people onto the advertorial who were never a match, who bounce almost immediately, who never read and never convert. To you that looks like a temporary win. To the native network's quality systems, it looks like an ad that sends garbage traffic to a page nobody engages with.

Those systems read poor post-click engagement and respond by throttling your distribution or repricing you upward — quietly punishing the whole campaign for the sin of one greedy image. This is why the ad image is not a maximum-clicks device. A great ad image is a **filter as much as a magnet**: it should attract the people the funnel can convert and let everyone else keep scrolling. Winning the wrong click is worse than winning no click at all.

## The Deeper Principle: Reader Warmth

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If you strip away the specifics, one idea explains why the jobs differ: **the image's assertiveness should match the reader's actual warmth — and warmth depends on which route your funnel runs.**

- A cold feed-scroller has no context and no patience. The ad image must communicate in a single glance and can't ask for anything but a click. This is true on both routes.
- On the **advertorial route**, a reader who clicked has demonstrated interest. The advertorial image has earned the right to carry more story, and by the time they reach the sales page they're genuinely warm.
- On the **jump-page route**, the reader who lands is only one click warmer than the feed. The jump-page image can't assume belief or borrowed trust; it keeps the curiosity the ad opened alive, makes the promise feel real and attainable, and lets the video do the real selling.

Match the image's assertiveness to the reader's actual warmth and everything feels natural. Get it backwards — a hard-selling, over-composed image thrown at an ice-cold scroller, or an image that presumes a warmth the reader never built — and the image works against the moment. Reader warmth is the principle underneath all the per-page rules you'll meet in this series. When a specific rule ever feels arbitrary, ask "how warm is the reader here, on this route?" and it usually explains itself.

## The One Law That Ties Them Together: Congruence

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Three places, three jobs — but on any one campaign they are not separate assignments. Your funnel's two images are acts of one story, and the same visual idea must run through both. The ad image opens a visual question; the middle page — advertorial or jump page, whichever your route runs — continues that exact subject and mood; the destination pays it off. This through-line is called **congruence**, and it's the thread the reader's scent follows from feed to video.

Congruence does *not* mean reusing the identical image. It means congruence of **idea** — each image re-expresses the same angle in the way its own job demands. On the advertorial route: the ad image's grabbed-on-a-phone shot of tired feet, then the advertorial's photo of the same person mid-day at work. On the jump-page route: the same ad image, then a jump-page shot carrying the same question forward and making the headline's promise feel real. Different photographs, one unmistakable idea. Break the idea and the reader feels lost even when each individual image is strong.

That's the whole reason "is this a good image?" has to become "good for which of the three places, and does it carry the same angle as the pages around it?" Congruence is important enough that it gets its own full treatment later (see *Document 6, Congruence: One Idea Through the Whole Funnel*) — here, just lock in that the three jobs are always in service of one story.

## How to Use This Series

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Every document that follows assumes the vocabulary you just learned: the three places an image works, their three jobs, reader warmth, qualified attention, congruence. When a document teaches a technique, it teaches the concept universally and then shows you how

it *dials* across the three places near the end — because almost nothing in image selection is a flat rule; most things are a setting that changes with where the image lives.

The companion documents go deeper on the tools: how expressive subjects and gaze direction pull the eye (*Document 2*); how visual curiosity and concealment open a loop (*Document 3*); what color actually does versus the folklore you've been taught (*Document 4*); why UGC-style authenticity beats produced polish (*Document 5*); congruence across the funnel (*Document 6*); the absolute compliance bans your ad images must never cross (*Document 7*); and the working process that turns all of it into a repeatable seven-step routine (*Document 8*).

Read them in any order once you have this one. But whichever technique you're applying, start every image decision the same way: **name where the image lives, name its job, then judge the image against that job.** That single habit is the foundation the entire series is built on.

## ✓ Key Takeaways

- There is no good image in the abstract. An image is only good *for the place it lives* — always name that place before you judge the image.
- There are three places across two alternative routes (ad → advertorial → sales page, or ad → jump page → VSL — the jump page never follows the advertorial). Each place has one job: the **ad image** wins qualified attention, the **advertorial** image confirms the scent, the **jump page** image — a second ad's image — builds curiosity, believability, and momentum toward the play.
- The ad image is a filter, not a maximum-clicks device. Cheap, wrong clicks poison the whole campaign, because networks throttle or reprice ads whose post-click engagement is poor.
- Match the image's assertiveness to the reader's actual warmth on your route: advertorial-route readers warm up through the story; a jump-page reader is only one click past the feed, so that image must keep the ad's loop open and make the promise feel attainable rather than assume belief.
- One law ties the three places together: **congruence** — the same visual idea, re-expressed for each job, running through the whole chain (full treatment in

*Document 6).*

- Whichever technique you apply from this series, start the same way every time: name where the image lives, name its job, judge the image against that job.